the Abor and Mishmi tribes, but its attention was more towards Northern Nagaland where it was engaged in operations against the Ao and Lotha tribes. In 1893, a 600-strong force (consisting of both the police and the army) under Captain Maxwell supported by 1,500 porters made its way up the Siang River Valley. The expedition, ostensibly to support the political officer who was to 'punish' the Abors for taking slaves, was tasked to push upriver as far as possible, then cross to the east and return along the Dibang River to Sadiya. The mission only partly succeeded, for the Abors succeeded in launching an attack on the expedition's base camp that left forty-five dead and forty-nine wounded.

By now, past experience in other sectors was also reinforcing the belief that the paramilitary usually functioned far more smoothly when it was not saddled with army troops. Not only were mixed expeditions less successful, the cost of using regular army troops was, in relative terms, quite prohibitive. This belief got further reinforced when in 1899 another mixed expedition (eight companies of regular army and sappers plus 200 men from the Lakhimpur Battalion) under Colonel Molesworth moved against the Mishmis. The three-month expedition cost the Government of India Rs 2 lakh. It was widely believed that had only the Lakhimpur troops been used, it would have cost considerably less and the goal would have been achieved more effectively.

As a result, over the next few decades in the run-up to Independence, the paramilitary force that became the Assam Rifles, functioned almost completely independently even though it was officered by army officers on deputation. It evolved its own style of functioning, which made it the ideal first line of defence for Thorat's plan where 'lightly equipped troops' would act as a screen, falling back on the defensive line while all the time harassing the advancing Chinese lines of communication. Despite holding the portfolio of External Affairs under which the Assam Rifles functioned, neither Prime Minister Nehru nor his advisers seemed to understand the importance of the Assam Rifles, which was not only tailor-made for the defence of NEFA, but had already done all the hard work by manning most of the border. Post 1959, after the army began to deploy in the Kameng and Lohit Frontier Divisions, the Assam Rifles became the poorer cousin which, much like the army, had no clear-cut role defined for it.

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